A Cross-Sectional Survey of School Administrators' Implementation Training, Knowledge, and Perceived Barriers

INTRO

- Implementation of evidence-based practices (EBPs) within a multi-tiered framework promotes equitable student outcomes[1,2]
- However, there is a gap between what is identified as "evidence-based" and what students receive
  Implementation science
- Leaders who are knowledgeable about implementation and engage in strategic decision making/action planning are associated with more favorable outcomes[3]
  - Research is limited in schools

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. To what extent are school administrators receiving pre-service/in-service training in implementation science?

2. What are school administrators' current knowledge and perceived competency related to key concepts/findings in implementation science?

3. What are school administrators' perceived challenges/barriers with real-world implementation in schools?

METHOD

- Participants included 173 administrators (50.3% female) employed in K-12 settings across 18 states
- 59-item survey was created to explore
  - Pre-service/in-service training
  - General implementation knowledge
  - Perceived barriers
- Data Analytic Approach
  - RQ 1: Descriptive Statistics
  - RQ 2: Bivariate Correlation Matrix
  - RQ 3: Proportions based on frequency of response (*moderate* or *major* barrier)

The **majority** of participating administrators received **limited to no pre-service training in implementation science**.

School **administrators'** perceived **knowledge/competency** were significantly and positively **associated** with their **overall training experiences.**

Sydney N. Pauling & Clayton R. Cook
School Psychology Program
College of Education and Human Development

Department of Educational Psychology
University of Minnesota
Driven to Discover®

[1] Garcia, A. R., Kim, M., & DeNard, C. (2016). Context Matters: The State of Racial Disparities in Mental Health Services Among Youth Reported to Child Welfare in 1999 and 2009. *Children and Youth Services Review*, *66*, 101-108. [2]U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. (2001). Mental Health: Culture, Race, and Ethnicity—*A Supplement to Mental Health: A Report of the Surgeon General*. *Rockville, MD.*
[3] Aarons, G. A., Ehrhart, M. G., Farahnak, L. R., & Sklar, M. (2014). The Role of Leadership in Creating a Strategic Climate for Evidence-Based Practice Implementation and Sustainment in Systems and Organizations. *Frontiers in Public Health Services and Systems Research*, *3*(4), 3. [4]Langley, A. K., Nadeem, E., Kataoka, S. H., Stein, B. D., & Jaycox, L. H. (2010). Evidence-Based Mental Health Programs in Schools: Barriers and Facilitators of Successful Implementation. *School Mental Health*, *2*(3), 105-113. doi:10.1007/s12310-010-9038-1. [5]Fixsen, D., Blasé, K., Metz, A., & Van Dyke, M. (2013). Statewide Implementation of Evidence-Based Programs. *Exceptional Children*, *79*(2), 213-230. doi:10.1177/001440291307900206

RESULTS

Research Question 1

- **~81% reported receiving no university coursework on implementation science**
- Specific PD on implementation science to facilitate systems change? **57% said no**
- *How important is implementation science in pre-service/in-service training for administrators?*
  - 84% **very** or **extremely important**

Research Question 2

- Respondents felt **least competent** in their **understanding of multi-level factors that enable or obstruct implementation**
- Highest correlation, ($r(152)=.438$, $p<.01$), between mean competency and *"Have you received specific PD on using implementation science to facilitate systems change?"*
- 3 items significantly predicted overall mean competency:
  - How well pre-service program prepared them to support implementation of EBPs
  - Overall effectiveness of PD offerings on improving influence uptake/ use of EBPs
  - Whether respondents received dedicated PD on how to use implementation science to facilitate systems change

Research Question 3

- Most commonly reported barriers were **staff acceptability** and **time**

CONCLUSION

- Findings are especially concerning due to consistent research suggesting administrators as one of the most significant barriers/facilitators to successful implementation[4]
- As staff acceptability/buy-in was most commonly reported barrier, this highlights importance of consultation targeting staff behavior change
- Implementation science must be integrated into training programs if society expects favorable return on investment on researching EBPs[5]